with ‘a desire to behold the various kingdoms of the world … with my own eyes’. He goes on: ‘Longing for novelty as a thirsty man longs for fresh water, I departed from these places as being well known to all … Wherefore spreading our sails on a favourable wind, and having implored the Divine aid, we committed ourselves to the sea.’[1]

In December 1502 Ludovico took ship from Venice bound for Egypt and beyond. In Damascus he enrolled as a supposed Mamluk slave soldier under the name of Yunas, or Jonah, and in this disguise served as an escort on a Hajj pilgrimage caravan to Medina and Mecca. In Aden he was imprisoned as a Christian spy and only secured his release by feigning madness. After months wandering around the Persian Gulf he met an Iranian merchant named Cazazioner (probably Khwaja Junair) who also wanted to see the world. So in the autumn of 1504 Ludovico and Cazazioner together sailed across the Arabian Sea to the Malabar coast – only to find themselves in a hornets’ nest.

The Arabs had already been trading up and down the Malabar coast for centuries, and had benefited mightily from both their mastery of the sea lanes between India and the Mediterranean world and their monopoly of the spectacularly profitable spice trade. Both these prizes were now in the process of being wrested from Arab hands by a younger and far more truculent power, the Portuguese, under the command of the self-proclaimed Viceroy of Goa. This transfer of power was taking place with bewildering speed, all stemming from that fatal moment on 22 April 1498 when an elderly Omani named Shaykh Ahmed ibn Majid climbed aboard Vasco da Gama’s *San Gabriel*, flagship of the First India Armada, in the East African port of Melinde. This was an exceptional stroke of luck for da Gama because ibn Majid happened to be the greatest navigator of the age. He came from a long line of master mariners originally from eastern Oman who had made names for themselves as